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RESEARCH NOTE

"Chief engagement officers?" A comparative study between U.S. corporate and nonprofit executive Leaders' social media communication strategies

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Abstract

Organizational leaders are increasingly expected to be visible and communicative on social media with organizations' public. Drawing theory and literature from dialogic communication and leadership communication, this study analyzed and compared how corporate and nonprofit executive leaders capitalized on various dialogic principles and social presence strategies for engagement purposes. We content-analyzed Twitter posts from leaders in corporate and nonprofit sectors. Findings revealed notable differences in how corporate and nonprofit executives communicated with publics on Twitter. While leaders from both sectors posted information valuable to their stakeholders and used affective strategies to project a personable image and nurture relationships, nonprofit leaders focused on social influence, whereas corporate executives emphasized information dissemination. This study also showed mixed findings regarding the relationships between leaders' communication strategies and publics' social media engagement.

KEYWORDS

dialogic communication, executive leaders, leadership communication, nonprofit, social media, social presence

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1 | INTRODUCTION

Executive leaders, including CEOs, heads of business units, and top managers, are the faces of their organizations who define organizations' cultural DNA (Men & Bowen, 2017; Park & Berger, 2004). In recent years, top leaders are increasingly expected to serve as corporate representatives to directly communicate and engage with their stakeholders via digital media (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018; Huang & Yeo, 2018; Kim & Sung, 2020). The role of CEOs as organizations' "chief engagement officers" and "corporate ambassadors" has become increasingly salient. This is partly driven by the rapid development of digital channels that have facilitated two-way, participatory, and personalized communication between organizations and their stakeholders. Further, there has been a rising demand from organizations' stakeholders, who now desire open and direct communications with organizational leadership (Huang & Yeo, 2018; Men et al., 2018; Wu et al., 2021).

The latest scholarship has provided empirical insights into mediated leadership communication. A majority of studies focused on executive leaders of the corporate world, featuring top social CEOs in the for-profit sector (Men et al., 2018), top startup CEOs (Yue et al., 2019), and Fortune 1000 CEOs (Huang & Yeo, 2018). In comparison, few explored how leaders from the nonprofit sector utilize social media to engage with stakeholders. Little effort has been made to compare whether and how top leaders from the two sectors (i.e., nonprofit vs. for-profit) may employ different communication styles and strategies (Rowold et al., 2014).

Drawing from the dialogic communication framework and leadership communication literature, the current study aims to understand the extent to which top leaders from the two sectors differ in applying digital dialogic principles and social presence strategies. We also endeavored to understand if and how these communication strategies can foster public engagement as indexed by the volumes of likes, retweets, and comments and whether these associations vary by the type of leaders we examined.

2 | LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 | Corporate and nonprofit leadership

Nonprofit and for-profit organizations are set apart by a series of fundamental differences. In terms of ownership and responsibility, the primary obligation of for-profit organizations is to maximize profits and shareholder (financial) value. In comparison, nonprofits prioritize creating social changes and are equally responsible to multiple stakeholder groups, including employees and volunteers, donors and supporters, policymakers and legislative bodies, and clients to whom they provide products and services (Hull & Lio, 2006). Oftentimes, the greater number of constituents complicates the decision-making process of nonprofits and their standards to evaluate nonprofit success (Thach & Thompson, 2007). It follows that nonprofit leaders are expected to be more open to environmental influences and initiate dialogue with multiple stakeholders to understand, identify, and satisfy their diverse needs (Carlson & Donohoe, 2010; Hull & Lio, 2006). Not surprisingly, nonprofit leaders also face more diverse performance expectations. Unlike for-profits with a simpler model that considers shareholder gain as a primary performance goal, leaders of nonprofits need to evaluate organizational performance based on "legal constraints, the original mandate of the organization, evolving external factors, and the current interests of internal decision-makers–the needs of a widely diverse group of stakeholders" (Hull & Lio, 2006, p. 56).

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The difference between the two sectors also lies in funding resources and risk tolerance. For-profits rely on investors, banks, and sales revenue, whereas nonprofits need to seek out private donations, corporate sponsorships, government funds, and crowdfunding, among other methods (Waters, 2014). In addition, nonprofits are more risk-averse (Hull & Lio, 2006). If a nonprofit fails to deliver its promised goods or services, it has failed to fulfill its social responsibility, which could result in harsher punishment from supporters, who will stop their donations. Furthermore, leaders of nonprofits are facing growing pressure to demonstrate accountability and effectiveness to both internal and external stakeholders. With high-profile scandals occurring in the third sector, "public trust of non-profits is not anymore a taken-for-granted matter" (Ahmed, 2005, p. 914), and the third sector is "being held up to scrutiny by the wider community" (Hodges & Howieson, 2017, p. 74).

Taliento and Silverman (2005) identified several areas of challenges that nonprofit CEOs uniquely face, including a more complex structure of responsibility, a broader range of stakeholders who expect consensus, the requirement for external communication, and managing organizations with limited resources and training. Along this line, previous research has identified a list of essential characteristics of successful nonprofit leaders, including a strong value-base, fundraising ability, communication skills, interpersonal skills, attention to external issues, and networking (Chambers & Edwards-Stuart, 2007; Herman & Heimovics, 1994).

It is noteworthy that fundraising and communication are the most valued experiences and skills for nonprofit leaders (Ahmed, 2005). Advocacy and fundraising are vital tasks for nonprofit executives, which require exceptional political and communication skills (Carlson & Donohoe, 2010; Taliento & Silverman, 2005). Because nonprofits typically have fewer resources and staff, nonprofit leaders assume a more entrepreneurial role than corporate chief executives (Taliento & Silverman, 2005). This means that nonprofit leaders need to get in front of people to drive media attention, foster strategic partnerships and collaborations across sectors, stay in touch with the community it serves to communicate and advocate their mission and boost people's awareness and motivation to support the nonprofit (Balser & McClusky, 2005; Grimm, 2018; Yang, 2012). In this respect, the role of nonprofit leaders in serving as chief fundraisers and external communicators to actively build relationships and engagement with stakeholders is more common and crucial than for-profit leaders (Ahmed, 2005; Dollinger, 1984; Taliento & Silverman, 2005).

2.2 | Impact of executive leadership communication

Communication is central to excellent leadership as it not only helps foster employees' positive work-related attitudes and behaviors but also cultivates engagement and quality relationships with external stakeholders. For instance, research shows that top leaders' charismatic and visionary communication during organizational turmoil could ameliorate the negative circumstance and elicit employees' supportive behaviors (Yue, 2021; Venus et al., 2019). A growing line of research that focused on leaders' digital communication has investigated the usage of interactivity, dialogue, personalization, self-disclosure, and tones, as well as their respective impact on public engagement (e.g., Huang & Yeo, 2018; Kim & Sung, 2020; Men et al., 2018; Wu et al., 2021). For instance, research shows that corporate CEOs' responsive and assertive online communications enhanced the public's trust in, satisfaction with, and advocacy for the company (Tsai & Men, 2017). Another study revealed that corporate CEOs' self-disclosure elicited more positive attitudes toward the CEO and the brand from the online publics (Kim & Sung, 2020).

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To our knowledge, the communication styles of nonprofit executives were not explored, nor was there evidence of the effectiveness of nonprofit leadership communication on digital platforms. However, as noted earlier, the publics expect nonprofits to be more transparent in disclosing what they do, how they spend their funding, and the effectiveness of their operations (Salamon, 2010). As ambassadors and representatives of their organization, we contend that nonprofit leaders are expected to take on a more active role in communicating their nonprofit's mission, value, and events. Executives of nonprofits may also be more engaged in interactive conversations with online stakeholders, such as potential donors, to fulfill their fundraising role. In addition, unlike their for-profit counterparts who have ample staffing and funding support for communication, it is likely that nonprofit leaders do not have sufficient resources to develop digital communication strategies, which consist of what, when, and to whom the communication should target. In summary, due to the differential nature of their responsibilities, the content and communication style of nonprofit and for-profit leaders should be also different. Leadership cannot be separated from communication as organizational leaders spend 70%–80% of their time communicating (Wajcman & Rose, 2011). Although there has not been any systematic comparison between nonprofit and for-profit leaders in terms of their *digital communication* practice, we argue such differences are self-evident and are deserving of further examination.

2.3 | Dialogic communication and social media engagement

This study draws from the dialogic communication framework (Kent & Taylor, 2002) to explore how executive leaders from the nonprofit and the corporate sector use digital dialogic principles and social presence strategies. Dialogic communication is an ethical, relational orientation aimed at building mutual understanding and long-term relationships between organizations and their publics (Kent & Lane, 2017). True dialogue encompasses five features: mutuality (collaboration and mutual equality between organizations and publics), propinquity (dialogic exchanges and mutual consultation before decision-making), empathy (trust and support during dialogue), risk (embracing the unpredictability and relational risks inherent in dialogic communication), and commitment (organizations' and publics' commitment to conversations and interpretations) (Kent & Taylor, 2002). In the current study, the operationalization of dialogic communication consists of both the functional (i.e., operationalized as dialogic principles) and the relational (i.e., operationalized as social presence strategies) dimensions.

The functional dimension of dialogic communication took in the form of five principles (Kent & Taylor, 2002), including generation of return visits (features that attract visitors back to the website), conservation of visitors (features that keep visitors on the website), dialogic loop (features that allow organizations to solicit feedback), usefulness of information (providing valuable and relevant information to stakeholders), and ease of interface (features that render publics' website navigation simple and easy). Since its conception, digital dialogic principles have attracted considerable research attention and have been applied across various digital platforms and organizations (Sommerfeldt & Yang, 2018). In particular, scholars have explored how different nonprofit organizations have employed these dialogic principles on websites, Facebook, Twitter, and WeChat (e.g., Bortree & Seltzer, 2009; Olinski & Szamrowski, 2017; Qu, 2020; Wang & Yang, 2020).

Despite the utility of digital dialogic principles in analyzing website content and social media posts, scholars have raised questions on whether these principles can adequately capture

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the essence of dialogue (Kent & Lane, 2017; Kent & Theunissen, 2016; Taylor & Kent, 2014). A major criticism is that dialogic principles are primarily functional and do not reflect dialogic communication's relational and interpersonal nature (Men et al., 2018; Saxton & Waters, 2014). Given that, recent research (e.g., Men et al., 2018; Yue et al., 2019) has incorporated the concept of *social presence* into the operationalization of dialogic communication to align with the original *dialogue* envisioned by Kent and Taylor (2002).

Social presence is defined as "the degree of salience of the other person in the interaction and the consequent salience of the interpersonal relationships" (Short et al., 1976, p. 65). In the computer-mediated communication setting, social presence refers to the immediacy and intimacy one perceives from other mediated communication partners (Lombard & Ditton, 1997; Rice, 1993). Strong social presence has been shown to foster interpersonal relationships (Kietzmann et al., 2011), parasocial relationships (Thorson & Rodgers, 2006), and favorable evaluations toward the mediated partner (Lee & Jang, 2013).

The current study examined the extent to which executive leaders of for-profits and nonprofits demonstrated social presence in their social media communication. We investigated three social presence strategies derived from previous research (Men et al., 2018; Rourke et al., 1999). The first is affective strategy, which refers to leaders' expression of personal emotions, feelings, opinions, and humor to build trust, empathy, and rapport with the public. Second, the interactive strategy includes showing agreement with and appreciation of others and engaging in two-way communication, which corresponds to the mutuality and propinquity focus of dialogic communication. Third, cohesive strategy involves using inclusive language to foster a sense of togetherness and relationship commitment. Taken together, social presence strategies complement functional dialogic principles to capture the social and interpersonal dimensions of dialogic communication.

We asked the following research questions to explore the use of dialogic principles and social presence strategies by executive leaders from the two sectors:

RQ1. How do corporate and nonprofit executive leaders differ in utilizing digital dialogic principles on Twitter, if any?

RQ2. How do corporate and nonprofit executive leaders differ in utilizing social presence strategies on Twitter, if any?

This study also endeavors to understand whether and how leaders' dialogic communication is associated with publics' social media engagement. Social media engagement reflects publics' openness and willingness to participate in conversations and discussions with executive leaders, which contributes to organization-public relationship building (Zhou & Xu, 2021). Social media engagement comprises cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions (Dessart, 2017). Cognitive engagement refers to publics' attention and absorption of an object (e.g., a post). Affective engagement contains publics' enthusiasm and enjoyment with regard to an object and is operationalized as categories of emotions in their comments (Dessart, 2017; Huang et al., 2021). Behavioral engagement is defined as publics' behavioral interactions with the focal object and is operationalized as the number of likes, retweets, and comments (Huang et al., 2021). The behavioral perspective classifies concrete actions undertaken by online publics and provides more actionable insights (Pentina et al., 2018). This approach also more closely corresponds to the behavioral analytics metrics used to evaluate social media marketing in practice. Although these metrics are reduced indicators of engagement, they have been examined in previous social

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media communication research (e.g., Men et al., 2018; Wang & Yang, 2020; Yue et al., 2021). Focusing on pubilcs' behavioral engagement, we asked the following research question:

> **RQ3.** How do digital dialogic principles and social presence strategies affect public engagement behaviors differently for corporate and nonprofit executive leaders?

3 | METHOD

3.1 | Sampling

Corporate executives were sampled from the renowned top Fortune U.S. companies list in 2017, and nonprofit executives were selected from the Nonprofit Times 100 list published in 2019. Following previous works (i.e., Yue et al., 2019), we randomly selected 18 leaders from each list and sampled 20 posts from each leader. The leaders' Twitter accounts were authenticated in prior studies. In total, we analyzed 295 posts from corporate leaders and 360 posts from nonprofit leaders.[1]

3.2 | Coding scheme

This study coded both the functional (i.e., dialogic principles) and relational (i.e., social presence strategies) features of dialogic communication. All the items were borrowed directly from well-established literature. In line with Men et al. (2018) and Rybalko and Seltzer (2010), digital dialogic principles were coded with four sub-categories: conservation of visitors, generation of return visits, dialogic loop, and information of interest to stakeholders.[2] Social presence strategies consisted of affective, interactive, and cohesive strategies taken from Rourke et al. (1999) and Men et al. (2018). We coded individual items under each sub-category (see Table S1). Finally, public engagement was operationalized as the number of likes, retweets, and comments. All items were coded as 0 being "no" and 1 being "yes."

3.3 | Coding procedure

Given that this study extracted data from two published studies (blinded for peer review), we did not undergo a new coding procedure. The authors of the two studies first coded 10% of randomly selected posts from the sample. Discrepancies were discussed and resolved. The coders then split and independently coded the remaining posts. Intercoder reliabilities of the two previous studies were satisfactory (Study 1 intercoder reliability: .86–.1.00; Study 2 intercoder reliability: .74–1.00) (Popping, 1988).

3.4 | Data analysis

We conducted multiple one-way ANOVAs and Chi-Square tests to answer RQ1 and RQ2. In addition to comparing the differences in their overall usage of the four dialogic principles and three social presence strategies (as broad categories, added up all individual item scores), we

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also analyzed leaders' differences in using specific individual-level strategies (e.g., the use of hashtags) (see Table S1). We used one-way ANOVAs to examine the differences in broad categories, and chi-squared tests to delve into individual-item differences. A series of negative binomial regressions were run to address RQ3.[3] Negative binomial regression is used to address the over-dispersed count data that do not follow a normal distribution (i.e., like, retweet, comment).

4 | RESULTS

RQ1 asks whether and how corporate and nonprofit executive leaders differ in using digital dialogic principles. Findings from the ANOVA tests showed that corporate leaders adopted higher levels of *conservation of visitors* ($F[1, 654] = 29.27$, $p < .001$). However, the two sets of leaders did not differ significantly in their overall use of *generation of return visits*, *dialogic loop*, or *information of interest to stakeholders*, despite specific item-level differences (e.g., The two sets of leaders differed significantly in "the use of hashtags," see Table S1, explained further in discussion). RQ2 asks whether and how they differ in using affective, interactive, and cohesive strategies. Findings indicated that while all three social presence strategies were utilized by corporate and nonprofit executive leaders, corporate executives overall employed higher levels of affective ($F[1, 654] = 36.03$, $p < 0.001$) and cohesive strategies ($F[1, 654] = 55.39$, $p < 0.001$) whereas nonprofit leaders used more interactive strategies ($F[1, 654] = 5.77$, $p < 0.05$). Individual item-level differences were also observed in corporate and nonprofit executives' use of these strategies (Table S1, further explained in discussion).

RQ3 explores the associations between executive leaders' communication strategies and public engagement and compares the differences between nonprofit and corporate executives. A series of negative binomial regressions were performed with leaders' number of followers controlled. Findings were mixed (see Table S2). *Conservation of visitors* negatively influenced the number of likes, retweets, and comments for corporate leaders while positively affecting the number of retweets for nonprofit leaders. We also observed a similar pattern for *generation of return visits*. *Dialogic loop* was negatively related to the number of likes and retweets for both types of executives. Not surprisingly, we found a positive relationship between *information of interest to stakeholders* and all engagement indicators for corporate leaders. Moreover, it relates positively to the number of likes and retweets for nonprofit leaders. We next examined the relationships between three social presence strategies and public engagement indicators. We found that *affective strategy* is positively associated with the number of likes for both corporate and nonprofit leaders and relates positively to the number of comments for nonprofit leaders. Interestingly, *interactive strategy* is positively related to the number of likes, retweets, and comments for corporate leaders but related negatively to the number of likes and comments for nonprofit leaders. Finally, *cohesive strategy* only affected engagement with nonprofit executives. It is the only strategy positively associated with all three engagement indicators for nonprofit leaders.

5 | DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

Social media afford executive leaders the opportunity not only to update and inform stakeholders, and align them around vision and values, but also to engage in dialogic conversations and create meaningful relationships (Heavy et al., 2020; Men et al., 2018; Wu et al., 2021). Given the difference in missions, goals, and objectives of for-profit and nonprofit organizations and

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their respective executive leaders' functions, this study intends to explore how executives of these two distinct sectors use social media through the theoretical lens of dialogic communication. The study revealed several key findings. First, executive leaders from both sectors applied dialogic principles and social presence strategies in their social media engagement with notable differences. For instance, for the use of dialogic principles, *conservation of visitors*, including posting links to the website or other social network sites, was more commonly used by corporate executives than nonprofit leaders. This is likely due to the often-limited resources and constraints of finance and staffing at nonprofits (Taliento & Silverman, 2005) and the promotional goal of corporate leaders' social media usage (Men et al., 2018). Instead of linking to other organizational online resources, nonprofit executives would direct users to a news/opinion piece related to themselves, their nonprofits, or the cause (see "*generation of return visits*"), which also provides third-party validation. When sharing "*information of interest to stakeholders*," corporate executives promoted company events, activities, and services more often. In contrast, nonprofit executives were more likely to share in-depth content such as news reports, opinion pieces, and speeches, and advocate for the nonprofit vision/mission/goals. Indeed, as inherently value-laden and purpose-driven organizations, nonprofits bear the important task of advancing the cause they represent. Nonprofit executives, likewise, carry a critical role in advocating the nonprofits' mission in all possible ways (Balser & McClusky, 2005; Grimm, 2018), including on social media. In terms of capitalizing on the "*dialogic loops*," despite the negligible difference in aggregated usage, nonprofit executives were more likely to post questions to solicit feedback and tag people to engage in conversations or call to action than their corporate counterparts, which concurs with the mobilizing goal of nonprofits to encourage cause advocacy and solicit public support (Payton & Moody, 2008; Qu, 2020).

Second, corporate and nonprofit executives both used social presence strategies to establish immediacy and intimacy with online stakeholders, with differences observed at the item level. Overall, corporate executives tended to use more affective and cohesive strategies than nonprofit leaders, particularly in sharing details of personal life and opinions, using humor to project an authentic image, and using inclusive language and addressing names to strengthen a sense of community and closeness. This signals a strong relational orientation to build deeper bonds and affective connections with online publics (Men et al., 2018; Yue et al., 2019). Further, with today's consumers placing higher expectations on the companies' authenticity, corporate CEOs are trying to engage in a more personable and genuine manner in the social domain. In contrast, nonprofit executives used more interactive strategies (e.g., expressing agreement, referring to others' messages) to carry on conversations and facilitate discussion around an issue to seek outcomes related to an issue or shared efforts. They were also more likely to purely send salutations or greetings to express goodwill and positivity to nurture relationships. After all, online relationships built via social media engagement have been linked to donations and other behavioral support (Smitko, 2012). It is also worth noting that despite being commonly used among all executives, emotional expressions (e.g., emoticon, all-caps, repeated exclamation marks) were significantly more prevalent among nonprofit executives. This represents a form of direct emotional engagement, which not only shows the personal side of the leader but can also be instrumental in mobilizing publics to advocate, act, contribute, and promote collective actions (Heavy et al., 2020). In addition, the use of emotional stories, metaphors, and appeals could help influence and promote change, align the frames of stakeholders, and garner support (Heavy et al., 2020), consistent with the general goals of nonprofits.Another stream of major findings concerns the influence of executives' use of dialogic communication on public engagement, which indicated differences among corporate and nonprofit leaders. Overall, for

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corporate executives, the only dialogic principle that significantly boosted public engagement indicated by likes, shares, and retweets was "*information of interest to stakeholders*." This speaks to the continued relevance and importance of using social media for strategic information dissemination and processing, especially in an era when consumers increasingly refer to social channels for information (Men et al., 2018). With regard to establishing a social presence, both affective and interactive strategies were found to work effectively for corporate executives. This finding suggests that publics appreciated corporate leaders' efforts to be personable, genuine, and authentic on social media by sharing personal life stories, opinions, telling jokes, or expressing emotions, truly bringing a distant CEO image to life. Corporate executives could also better engage the publics by using interactive strategies to initiate or facilitate conversations (e.g., expressing agreement, appreciation/compliment).

Interestingly, all dialogic principles but *dialogic loop* effectively encouraged public engagement on Twitter for nonprofit CEOs. This highlights the importance for nonprofit executives to better utilize social media's informational function, such as posting links to websites, articles, or other organizational resource sites, broadcasting nonprofit activities, events, and more importantly, sharing the nonprofit's mission and goals to make what they do and advocate for visible to the online stakeholders (Grimm, 2018). As for projecting social presence, both affective and cohesive strategies were effective in enhancing public engagement. Therefore, nonprofit executives should embrace social media's interpersonal nature to present an authentic self by sharing appropriate personal stories, opinions, feelings, or humility. They should also make greater efforts to sustain a sense of community and group commitment by, for instance, using inclusive pronouns ("we," "us," "our"). Such sense of togetherness and inclusiveness could enhance publics' identification with the nonprofit community (cf. Men & Tsai, 2016), leading to support for the cause.

In sum, the study showed that both corporate and nonprofit executives utilized digital dialogic principles and social presence strategies to engage online stakeholders, although to different degrees. Corporate executives tend to capitalize on social media engagement for information processing (e.g., to inform, update and exchange knowledge with stakeholders) (Heavy et al., 2020) and relationship building (Men et al., 2018; Yue et al., 2019); nonprofit executives tend to engage with publics on social media for relationship nurturing and social influence (e.g., to align publics around missions, values, and issues, to mobilize and advocate for causes), reflecting the distinctive goals and functions of for-profit and nonprofit organizations. Sharing "information of interest to stakeholders" and using affective strategies to project a personable and authentic image and create a sense of intimacy seems to be the common denominator for both corporate and nonprofit executives' social engagement efforts.

Top leaders' communicative function has become increasingly salient under the megatrends of rapid technological advancement and escalated public demand for business leaders to drive social change (Dailey, 2021). It's not a question of whether but how executive leaders should capitalize on the unique features of social media to inform, connect, and engage with online stakeholders, foster genuine dialogue, create deeper bonds, and align them with organizational purpose and goals. As one of the earliest empirical attempts to compare corporate and nonprofit executives' use of social media, this study contributes to the theorization of leadership communication in the social media arena and extends the application of dialogic communication framework to leadership communication. Specifically, this study adds to the emergent discussion regarding the benefits of social media-mediated leadership communication (Huang & Yeo, 2018; Tsai & Men, 2017). In addition, by incorporating social presence as a key dimension of dialogic communication, this study enriches our understanding of dialogic communication from both a functional and relational perspective.

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We also provide timely practical insights for corporate and nonprofit leaders to be more effective "chief engagement officers" in the digital age. Specifically, organizational leaders, regardless of corporations or nonprofits, should be cognizant of their increasingly important strategic communication roles internally and externally for their organizations and proactively enhance their communication skills or seek professional help from the communication team or external consultants. At the practical level, organizational leaders should capitalize on both the functional and relational features of social media to provide information relevant and useful to stakeholders, facilitate and engage in social conversations, project an authentic leadership image, and build meaningful stakeholder relationships in the digital sphere. In addition, academic programs should prepare future leaders to be effective communicators, for instance, by providing leadership communication courses to business and public policy students.

Building on the findings of this study, future researchers could extend the comparative efforts to explore further why corporate and nonprofit executives' social communication strategies vary through qualitative investigations (e.g., in-depth interviews, case studies). Larger sets of corporate and nonprofit CEO communication data can also be collected from other dominant social media platforms such as Facebook at the same time period to address the current study's limitation. As organizational leaders are expected to be more visible, vocal, and communicative in today's VUCA environment (Dailey, 2021), more research is needed on executive leadership communication. In particular, the logistics of nonprofit CEOs playing the chief engagement officers' roles (e.g., personnel support, integration of online/offline strategies) is worthy of further investigation. It would also be worthwhile to explore what strategies and tactics are effective in appealing to specific stakeholders (e.g., donors, volunteers, policymakers, etc.) or to different segments of publics (e.g., millennials and Gen-Z). Furthermore, this study focused on behavioral manifestations of public social media engagement. Future research should incorporate cognitive and affective dimensions to understand social media engagement in a holistic manner. Last, other individual or organizational factors may affect public engagement with the leaders' posts. For example, top executives' tenure with the current organization may influence the number of likes, retweets, and comments s/he received and therefore needs to be controlled in the analysis.

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CONFLICT OF INTEREST

No competing financial interests exist.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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ENDNOTES

[1] Following Yue et al. (2019), this study did not count pure retweets ($N = 65$) from corporate leaders, thus resulting in a smaller sample size compared to the nonprofit leader group.

[2] *Ease of interface* is excluded because this feature is indiscriminate and by default in all Twitter profiles.

[3] Dialogic principles and three social presence strategies were constructed as broad categories by adding up all individual item scores. For instance, if the CEO's post included three out of five items of "dialogic loop", the overall "dialogic loop" score that specific post gets is a 3.

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